

"The Art of Active Listening"

Amy Gallo | Harvard Business Review | YouTube search: "The Art of Active Listening Harvard Business Review Guide"

Name: _____ Period: _____ Date: _____

■ WHAT THIS VIDEO IS ABOUT

Amy Gallo, contributing editor at Harvard Business Review, opens with a direct challenge: you might think you're a good listener — but you're probably not. Common behaviors like nodding, saying "mm-hmm," and repeating back what someone said can actually leave the speaker feeling dismissed. In this video, Gallo breaks down what active listening actually looks like, why it matters in professional settings, and the specific questions you can ask yourself to become a genuinely better listener at work.

Review Questions — Answer as You Watch or Immediately After

Answer in the space provided. Complete sentences are required.

Question 1 — Sponge vs. Trampoline

Gallo introduces two types of listeners — the sponge and the trampoline. What is the difference between them? Which one are most people, and why does it fall short in a professional setting?

Question 2 — Listening Styles

Gallo describes four different listening styles: task-oriented, analytical, relational, and critical. Pick one and explain when it would be the right style to use at work — and when using it at the wrong moment could cause a problem.

Question 3 — What You're Missing

Gallo says good listening means paying attention to what is left unsaid, not just what is spoken. She gives an example of an employee worried about a presentation. What was the wrong response and what was the better one — and why does the difference matter?

Question 4 — Getting in Your Own Way

Gallo says one of the biggest barriers to deep listening is our own internal monologue — our insecurities, our urge to respond, our need to seem prepared. How does this internal noise interfere with professional communication, and what does she suggest doing about it?



Read the scenario carefully. Respond in complete sentences. One-sentence answers will not receive full credit.

Scenario Question

A healthcare clinic supervisor holds a weekly check-in with her team. During one meeting, a medical assistant named Jordan says: "I've been having a hard time keeping up with the patient intake volume lately." The supervisor responds: "Oh, it gets easier — I was totally overwhelmed my first year too. Just push through it. Anyone else have updates?" Jordan goes quiet for the rest of the meeting. Two weeks later, Jordan submits a resignation letter. In the exit interview, Jordan says she felt like no one at the clinic was actually listening to her concerns.

Using Gallo's framework from the video, break down exactly what went wrong in that check-in conversation. What type of listener was the supervisor being? What was left unsaid that the supervisor missed completely? Write out what a trampoline listener would have said instead — word for word — and explain why it would have changed the outcome. Respond in at least 4 complete sentences.

